

ON THE TRAIL A still from the web series *The Hunt*, directed by Nagesh Kukunoor

Sivarasan (a menacing Shafeeq Mustafa). The LTTE's suicide-for-a-cause strategy has inspired a few narratives such as *The Terrorist*, *Madras Café* and, more recently, season two of *The Family Man*. *The Hunt*'s approach sees it briefly mention how Gandhi's deployment of the IPKF in Sri Lanka stoked LTTE's animosity against him. The writers also don't shy away from information such as how the organisation had sympathisers in Tamil Nadu, but don't delve too deep into what triggered the support. "In your eyes, they are terrorists; in their eyes, they are freedom fighters," explains one character to the investigating officers. "I treat my characters with a tremendous amount of subjectivity and humanity," says Kukunoor. "Heroes are easy to understand; perpetrators of crime are not so easily understood." *The Hunt* continues Kukunoor's productive streak on streaming, which has seen him deliver two seasons of *City of Dreams* (Disney+ Hotstar), create a *Modern Love* (Amazon Prime) anthology set in Hyderabad and face the camera in a supporting part for season two of *Paatal Lok* (2025). It has also piqued curiosity about when he will return to directing independent features. "It is nice to talk about independent cinema, of having a strong voice, but it is so freaking difficult to make independent cinema now," he says. It's been a topic of much discussion between him and Sameer Nair of Applause Entertainment, which has produced both his web series. Instead of fretting, Kukunoor is finding a way. "I do what I do. To say I am an anomaly reeks of hubris. I am still in some weird twilight space," he says. It seems to be working.

He stays away from social media—his last Instagram post was in 2019, he boasts. The freedom from distraction means he can begin his day by writing for up to four hours and be prolific. He has canned another web series with Applause. "The fact that I am still here working after 27 years is proof that I do what I like," he adds. "What I have done in the last six to seven years is to be creatively satisfied." ■

—Suhani Singh

Born on May 31, 1925, in undivided Punjab, Khosla's parents moved to Bombay when he was just three. While the book is sketchy about his early years, it does trace his love for music to his admiration for K.L. Saigal, a neighbour in Matunga's Punjabi Galli. He was so passionate about music that he even learnt Hindustani classical under Pandit Jagannathbuwa Purohit. Khosla began his career in the movies as a stuntman, followed by short stints in playback singing and acting. However, he found his true calling only when he met Guru Dutt and Dev Anand.

Khosla considered Dutt to be his guru, and Anand was a frequent collaborator. The duo feature prominently in the book. Across over 20 chapters and a foreword by Mahesh Bhatt, who started out as one of Khosla's assistants, the book trains a lens on each of the films to show what made Khosla an exceptional filmmaker.

The book is a smorgasbord of anecdotes—both apocryphal and verified—that provide a peek into works that have shaped desi pop culture. Take the 'Jhumka Gira Re' track originally sung by Asha Bhosle for Khosla's *Mera Saaya* (1966). While lyricist Raja Mehdi Ali Khan retained the original *mukhda* (chorus) from the popular folk song, the rest of the lyrics are said to be inspired by Teji Suri who went on to marry eminent poet and author Harivansh Rai Bachchan.

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Featuring a veritable who's who of Khosla's collaborators and historic moments in filmmaking, the biography is a genuine page-turner. What Roychoudhury fails to do, though, is place Khosla's work in its historical and cultural context. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay